

Even the bar he chose, a brassy, ferny Fifth Avenue singles' stop, didn't seem to cheer him. He continued to talk about getting a "real job." I tried to make him tell exciting stories about futures. The only exciting stories he remembered were the orthodox Jew who made a fortune in pork bellies, and the trader who blew his nose in his tie.

We ended up at Mr. Gressel's apartment, where we waited for Claudia to get home from the *Wall Street Journal*. It was a one-bedroom place on Twenty-eighth Street and Fifth Avenue, not at all the penthouse I expected. In the galley kitchen, Mr. Gressel mangled an old loaf of bread and cut off some ragged hunks of cheese. We sat down on a soft couch and ate this appetizer while talking about Latin American politics.

Mr. Gressel had just put some left-wing Chilean folk music on the stereo, so I was surprised when he said he was a big fan of the right-wing Chilean dictator, Pinochet. It occurred to me later that this was a political version of hoping the markets will go up and down simultaneously. The sophisticated futures and options trader lives a very complicated mental life.

After a couple of hours, we turned off the music and turned on the TV to watch the latest episode of *Miami Vice*. Mr. Gressel was still preoccupied with his losses. He got half-involved in the Miami plot, then abandoned the show and headed for his desk, where he sat down to consider a pile of computer printouts. Finally, he made a phone call to one of his fellow traders, which I couldn't help overhearing. For 20 minutes they talked about implied volatility and how a "16" should really have been a "13," and Mr. Gressel's mood was visibly improved. After he hung up, he took out his little calculator, punched in some additional numbers, then turned toward me and exclaimed: "I was wrong! Wrong all the time! I wasn't down \$10,000 for the day. Really I was up ten thousand for the day."

The rest of the evening was gleeful. When Claudia returned home, Mr. Gressel told her to go out tomorrow and buy some new clothes. The three of us had a nice dinner at a restaurant.